

People

People of French descent make up about 94 per cent of the population. Among these are several groups who speak their own languages and have strong independence movements. These include the Bretons of Brittany in the north, about 500,000 Basques in the Pyrenees, and the Corsicans.



107 per sq km
(278 per sq mile)



75% Urban
25% Rural



Ethnic groups

France's five million immigrants include mainly North African Muslims and economic migrants from South and Central Europe. Most live and work in the cities.

Leisure

Football, rugby, cycling, and tennis are all popular sports in France, as are horseracing and Formula 1. The French Open is a major international tennis championship.

Tour de France

Each year, more than a hundred of the world's leading professional cyclists compete in this famous cycle race over a 3,400-km (2,113-mile) route in 24 one-day stages.

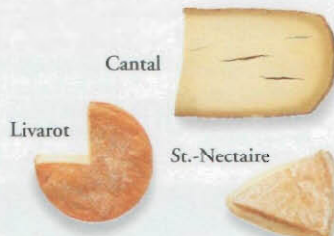


Boules

Throughout France, groups of people playing *boules* are a common sight in the town or village square. *Boules* is France's national game and involves rolling heavy balls at a smaller target ball.

Farming

The French grow a variety of crops, such as wheat, barley, sugar beet, and grapes for making wine. About a third of all the farmland is pasture for grazing cows and sheep, which are reared for milk to make dairy products, and for meat.



Cheese

France produces more than 365 kinds of cheese, from cow, sheep, and goats' milk. These include St-Nectaire, Cantal, and Livarot, and the famous Brie, Camembert, and Roquefort. Milk and butter are also important exports.

Cereals

France's main cereal crop is wheat, which grows on large farms in the north of France where the soil is good.



Wine

The wines of Bordeaux, Burgundy, Champagne, and the Rhône valley are sold worldwide. France is the leading producer and controls quality strictly.

Food

French cuisine is world famous, and words such as *café*, *restaurant*, *paté*, and *quiche* are common in many languages. Special French dishes include *bouillabaisse* (fish soup), *escargots* (snails), and *grenouilles* (frogs' legs).



Industry

France has strong chemical, steel, electronics, and manufacturing industries, and an active aerospace programme. Nuclear power provides three-quarters of the country's electricity. Perfume and fashion are also a major source of income.



Perfume

French perfumes, such as Chanel, are world famous. Many are made from the fragrant oils extracted from roses, jasmine, and lavender that grow in the southeast of the country.

Tourism

The fashionable resorts of the Côte d'Azur in southeast France attract thousands of tourists every summer. France is now the world's leading tourist destination, attracting 75 million visitors each year.



Car production

Most French drivers buy French cars, such as this Renault Espace. Other makes include Peugeot and Citroën. The French car industry ranks fourth in the world.



Transport

France boasts the world's fastest train, the TGV, which can travel at speeds of up to 300 kmh (186 mph). A direct service now runs to England via the Channel Tunnel.



Monaco

This tiny independent principality on the Côte d'Azur derives its income from tourism, banking, sales tax, and gambling. It has close ties with France.



Grand Casino

The people of Monaco pay very little tax and earn more per head than any other country in the world. The gaming rooms and roulette wheels of the Grand Casino in Monte Carlo are open to anyone with money to spend.

MONACO FACTS

CAPITAL CITY	Monaco
AREA	1.95 sq km (0.75 sq miles)
POPULATION	32,000
MAIN LANGUAGE	French
MAJOR RELIGION	Christian
CURRENCY	Euro

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